

Passages - Strait is the Gate

Nothing that I experienced later seems to me worthier of that name- and moreover, when I became old enough to suffer from the more definite qualms of the flesh, my feeling did not greatly change in character; I never sought more directly to possess her whom, as a child, I had sought only to deserve. Work, efforts, pious acts, offered them all up, mystically, to Alissa, and, indeed, invented a refinement of virtue by which I often left her in ignorance of what I had done only for her sake.

'Don't ask too much of me. I shouldn't care for Heaven if you were not there too.'

I wished for nothing beyond her smile, and to walk with her thus, hand in hand, along a sun-warmed, flower-bordered path.

Oh! give me back the happiness that I had; I can't do without it. I love you well enough to wait for you all my life, but that you should cease to love me or that you should doubt my love, that thought, Alissa, is unbearable to me.'

Abel's enthusiasm made short work of the present and the future.

The fear of troubling you prevents me from telling you how much I want you," [she wrote towards the end of the summer]. 'Every day that has to be got through before I see you again weighs on me, oppresses me. Another two months. It seems longer than all the rest of the time which has already gone by without you! Everything I take up to while away the hours, seems nothing but an absurd stop-gap, and I cannot set myself to anything.

My books are without virtue and without charm;
my walks have no attraction;
Nature has lost her glamour; the garden is emptied of colour, of scent.

I went out! I wanted to speak to you again, to tell you all the things I had not told you; I was already hurrying to the Plantiers' ... It was late; I didn't have time, didn't dare ... I came in again, desperate, to write to you - that I didn't want to write to you any more - a good-bye letter because I felt too much that our correspondence was nothing but a vast mirage, that we were each writing, alas! only to ourselves and that - Jerome! Jerome! Ah! how far apart we were all the time!

As soon as I begin to argue, my words freeze; I can only hear the weeping of my heart.

I love you too much to be skilful, and the more I love you the less I know what to say to you. "Intellectual love " ... what am I to answer to that? When it is with my whole soul that I love you, how can I distinguish between my intellect and my heart?

It is the hope of reaching you that will always make me think the steepest path the best.

And my whole heart's protest no longer even rose to my lips - it choked me.

The Alissa whom you think you still love, already exists only in your memory; a day will come when you will only remember that you loved her.

Was it not wiser to admit to myself that I had been mistaken?